the AIBA) World Women's Boxing Championships in Pennsylvania, USA, in November–December 2001.

My father managed to collect only Rs 2,000 for my trip. I was both upset and very worried because I'd heard of



how expensive things were in America. But there was nothing my parents or I could do. I spoke to Onler, one of my friends, about my problem. He invited a few students and elders, who went to meet the two Members of Parliament and seek their help. Two MPs donated Rs. 5,000 and Rs. 3,000 respectively and I suddenly had Rs 10,000 in my hands. With this **princely** sum, and a little more that had been collected from people, I left for the US. I was relieved to have money in my pocket, and knew that I could not come back empty-handed after all the efforts that people had made on my behalf.

Pennsylvania was cold and beautiful. It was snowing. We were confined to the sports arena, but what little I saw was pleasing to the eye. The people were enormously nice too. It was the first time in my life that I had travelled so far. I was looking forward to seeing what America was all about. But since we were the last team to arrive, we went straight to the sporting arena from the airport. The other teams had already completed their weight in, which is compulsory for all players. I was tired and suffering from **jet lag**. It had been morning when I left, and here it was morning again. After weighing in, I found out that I did not have any match that day. I was fortunate, but some of the team-mates were not so lucky. I was able to rest well enough to face my opponent in the round, which I won comfortably. My fear of facing new opponents quickly vanished. I competed in the 48 kg in this championship. While team-mates lost one after the other, I went on to reach the finals. I was even hopeful of winning the gold. The boxers were not unbeatable as I had earlier thought.

I felt like this would be the place, the event that would change my life. I kept telling myself, "I can face anyone in the ring." In the quarter–final, I defeated Nadia Hokmi of Poland by RSC (Referee Stopped Contest–applicable if the referee feels one of the boxers is inferior to the other and risks getting hurt badly), and in the semi-final, I defeated Jamie Behal of Canada by 21-9. I reached the finals, but lost to Hula Sahin of Turkey by 13-5.

The greatest disadvantage for me was my loss of **appetite**. I was not accustomed to the food there. Try as I might, I could not eat the food and I started to lose weight. So much so that just before the finals I was only 46 kg. This is probably what cost me my dream of winning gold and I was very disappointed. I went to my room and cried. But the coaches were kind; they consoled me and **lauded** me on the silver win. I was the only one in the team to get a medal. But the biggest thing

02-A-Prose-THE QUEEN OF BOXING.indd 35 11-01-2019 15:37:20